

Diploma in Leadership & Management

Remote team management



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Lesson outcomes

The student will be able to understand the fundamentals of virtual onboarding, working with different personalities remotely and the mental health impact of working remotely. The student will have gained better insights and strategies to tackle each of these aspects of business. The student will have gained a much better understand of onboarding virtually, personality management and mental health strategies that the workplace can offer.

Introduction

Virtual onboarding is becoming more and more popular it allows companies to focus on other areas of the onboarding process and helping the company thrive. This lessons looks at key elements of onboarding as well as personality management and finally we will have a look at the impact that remote work has on the mental health of employees. This lesson gives students a practical approach to overcome and improve these aspects of their business to improve the effectiveness of their teams.

Key reading materials:

- <https://aboutleaders.com/different-personalities/>
- <https://mhanational.org/blog/mental-health-benefits-remote-and-flexible-work>
- <https://weworkremotely.com/how-to-keep-your-mental-health-in-check-when-you-work-from-home>

Online interview Questions to ask:



According to (Redbooth, n.d.) here are the best practices when it comes to virtual onboarding.

Face-to-Face Welcome

It is essential for an employee to connect the face to a voice to be able to build a strong relationship. Using video conferencing is a great way to welcome remote employees to the company. It allows new employees to feel comfortable to ask questions and strengthens personal bonds. The use of video conferencing includes eye contact, observing body language and learning more about the person you are meeting, without the stress associated with travel. Redbooth allows for real-time communication with the use of HD video meetings, screen sharing and work chat. It is a great way to include virtual employees in meetings and to make sure they have a voice without being physically present.

Introduce Them to the Team

In a typical office environment, it's easy to forget about employees working remotely. The comfort of walking around the office and interacting with one another is something virtual employees are unable to experience. The key to a successful work environment is allowing new hires to experience the office regardless of where they are located. Take new hires on a virtual tour of the office in the comfort of their seats. Virtually walk them through the office, introducing various team members. Have co-workers welcome them to make them feel like they are also part of the family. This prevents new hires from feeling isolated and uninvolved. It is important to enable real time communication via chats and instant messages. This allows for remote employees to communicate with colleagues immediately, and help with the adjusting process of familiarizing new hires with their new role. Redbooth includes a great way to discuss potential projects and ideas, and share information. These conversations are easily turned into a task, making it easier to remember what must be done.

Be Extremely Organised

When onboarding a virtual employee, it's easy to get distracted and lose track of what must be done. It's essential to be extremely organised and have detailed outlines of everything you need done from your new employee. A good way to do this is with a shared document. Have one main document with an outline linking to several different related documents. Another good way is creating a task list with precise due dates. Creating a task list ensures that each employee is assigned to a specific task, and projects are completed on time. This reduces any confusion in the office and for employees who work from home. Redbooth is great for creating task lists and linking to other relevant tasks, documents, notes and conversations. To save time, it's very easy to use task list templates, which allow managers to create the same onboarding task list each time a new remote worker starts at the company.

Break It Up

If you are onboarding a virtual employee with many responsibilities, break them up into different parts and introduce them in steps. Confusion and misunderstanding can interrupt workflow, but with organization and clear instructions, employees will know exactly what is expected from them. In a traditional office environment, employees often attend classes or participate in on-the-job training, which is impractical with remote workers. Breaking up the content into building blocks that are taught in chunks is an effective learning process. Make sure an employee fully understands what is expected from them before moving on to the next step. When responsibilities are introduced gradually, they can be mastered more quickly, resulting in more efficiency and productivity.

Instil Culture

Virtual employees rarely step foot in the corporate office, making it easy to forget about company culture. Culture is just as important in onboarding as day-to-day responsibilities. As a company expands and starts to hire remote employees, they often find their culture unable to evolve in the process. Onboarding remote workers in terms of culture can be done through coaching, mentoring, and technology. Pairing remote employees with an "on-site" team member is the best practice to opening the lines of communication. Team members can ensure that virtual employees are well aware of the workflow, organizational values, business goals and performance expectations. Let remote employees know that they are free to communicate and ask questions whenever they feel the need to. When employees feel connected to the culture, they are more willing to work harder and feel as though they are making an impact.

Constantly Adjust

It's easy to neglect the effectiveness of the program once it's implemented. By regularly collecting feedback from remote new hires, you can improve and adjust to programs to ensure that they have a good start at your company. Once virtual employees have been on the job for a while, get in touch with them and review any concerns they may have. With technology today, there is no reason for remote employees to feel unwelcome by the organisation. It's vital to make their first encounters with the company positive and memorable, even if they are miles away.

Personality testing tools:



Here I have a list of personality tests that you can share with your team. You can select the one that you find the most useful and that can be used to assess the personalities of your team. During the lesson, I looked at the Meyer-Briggs personality test to determine how different personalities react in times of remote work. You can select any personality test that you want and conduct your own research. Please note that we covered some of these test in Module 1 and this will serve as a recap of the content we already covered.

According to (Matthews, n.d.), they have given the following break-downs and reviews of the different personality assessments:

California Psychological Inventory (CPI)

Companies use the CPI to look for employees who are likely to interact well with others, and the results predict how an individual will react under specific circumstances. The inventory offers feedback on work-related characteristics such as sociability, conceptual understanding, and independence.

Administrators claim this assessment is extremely reliable. In this field, reliability is the level of consistency shown when using the evaluation several times, and valid assessments measure what they claim.

Also, the design of the CPI helps identify respondents who falsify answers to improve their results; these respondents are sometimes allowed to retake the test.

Caliper Profile

The Caliper Profile looks at more than 25 personality traits that correlate to on-the-job achievement. It identifies strengths, weaknesses, and potential while also providing information about motivators. Specific attributes covered include empathy, leadership, and time management.

One of the advantages of this assessment is that it examines both positive and negative features, as well as certain personality aspects that are considered in relation to each other, which is helpful because not all employees need to have the same qualities, and some traits are either beneficial or possibly detrimental depending on the position. For example, in some jobs, aggressiveness is a bonus, whereas other roles may call for a more sensitive approach.

DISC Assessment

In the DISC assessment, questions about behaviors and beliefs categorize individuals within four personality styles—dominance, influence, steadiness, and conscientiousness—and test takers indicate how they would react to certain situations.

The results communicate general expectations about potential behaviors. For instance, people highly rated for steadiness are typically considered to be skilled in interpersonal interactions. However, for specific individuals, these assumptions are inaccurate.

The DISC assessment is not norm-referenced. In normative tests, an individual's score is compared to patterns of behavior found within large numbers of results, but DISC is ipsative, which means no comparisons are possible, and individual responses stand alone. Without the ability to contrast test takers' scores, the test can't predict future behavior but rather is more of a review of potential strengths and weaknesses.

Gallup StrengthsFinder

Instead of exploring a range of personality traits, this assessment focuses on strengths and highlights a person's top 5 attributes out of 34 possibilities, which include characteristics such as positivity, achievement, and helpfulness. This test came into existence following studies that found there are specific talents more likely to support success in the workplace. University of California, Los Angeles and Harvard psychology researchers refined these results.

The team that developed the test chose to focus on strengths to help people expand skills rather than self-correct faults, and it is a helpful employment assessment tool because it emphasizes traits that are important to workplace success but ignores unenlightening negatives, which reduces the chances an HR professional might fixate on a downside that doesn't link to future job success.

Minnesota Multiphasic Personality Inventory

A psychologist must supervise the administration and evaluation of this assessment, which is generally used to assess candidates' readiness for work settings where they might experience significant psychological stress, such as on the police force.

A participant usually completes the inventory on a computer, answering a large battery of true-or-false questions, and a psychologist then interprets the results.

However, this personality assessment is not appropriate for most businesses, as it covers too many areas unrelated to most work responsibilities.

Myers-Briggs Type Indicator

This well-known personality assessment looks at several variables: world focus, information-gathering, decision-making, and interaction style. Each is on a continuum.

The extremes for these variables are, respectively, introversion or extroversion, sensing or intuition, thinking or feeling, and judging or perceiving. Participants are categorized according to how their strongest traits interrelate.

Although this assessment is popular in corporate America and the results could help people improve their interactions with others, there is little psychological evidence that indicates it is a reliable measurement.

16 Personality Factor (pf) Questionnaire

The 16pf® Questionnaire is used in workplaces, academic settings, and counseling situations. It measures 16 personality dimensions, including warmth, social boldness, openness to change, self-reliance, and perfectionism.

Results are organized according to more general personality factors, such as extraversion, tough-mindedness, self-control, anxiety, and independence, which creates an overview that predicts behaviors.

Researchers have found the questionnaire to be valid when results are compared to similar assessments, and studies demonstrate the 16pf's validity through the similar results participants get when retested weeks or months later.

The SHL Occupational Personality Questionnaire (OPQ)

HR professionals use this test to determine how a person's behavioral style may affect how he or she will perform at work. This test measures 32 performance-relevant characteristics grouped into broad categories, such as relationships or sociability.

The questionnaire has 104 items arranged into blocks of 4 statements each. Test takers have to look at all the comments in a respective block and choose the one that is most true or typically true about themselves, as well as the statement that's least applicable. There is also a built-in social desirability measure intended to indicate when people give false responses. The British Psychological Society (BPS) evaluated the OPQ and gave it high marks—it received the highest-possible rating for quality, as well as high scores for validity and reliability.

The BPS also noted that the OPQ is well written and can be easily understood, which should help those taking the test to concentrate fully on each statement without feeling confused or overwhelmed. Even though the BPS evaluation happened a while ago, the clout of that organization helps give credibility to the results even today.

How to protect the mental health of your employees:



As stated by (Hirevelocity) here are some of the best approaches to better support the mental health of your remote employees.

Recognize the problem.

The first step in solving any problem is recognizing that it exists. Lack of social connection and face-to-face interaction, loneliness, distractions, and difficulty accessing necessary tools and information all contribute to poor engagement among remote workers. To solve the problem, train managers to understand how these factors affect the well-being and productivity of their teams. Training programs and protocols should also empower leaders to support employees with coaching and communication.

Coach employees on how to prioritize their own well-being.

Newly remote employees may initially struggle with establishing a functional work-at-home routine. Encourage them to prioritize their well-being by taking steps like these:

Shift focus – Don't stare at the computer screen for eight hours straight. Instead, work in intervals if possible. Try creating a rotation of tasks: focus computer work, phone calls, Zoom meetings, checking email, etc. Switch up your location with each task as you move through the day.

Take regular breaks – Whether it's a walk to the kitchen for coffee or a walk around the block, breaks give you a chance to regroup both mentally and physically.

Get exercise and sunshine – Exercise and sunshine both improve your mindset and energy levels. Open the blinds, take a quick walk outside, or do an exercise video before or after work each day.

Build social interaction into every day – Connect with colleagues via chat tools or video conferencing, and take the time to pick up the phone rather than sending an email when possible. In addition, look for ways to connect socially outside of work. Text a friend, call a family member, or send a message to someone you haven't heard from in a while.

Take time for reflection and gratitude – Clear your mental space by practicing mindfulness and gratitude.

Use technology to help employees stay connected.

Set up a virtual space where employees can interact and build connections. Tools like Zoom, Slack, and Facebook can all meet the critical need for social connection, while also promoting collaboration at work. And while it's important to keep employees on task, allowing them the freedom to chat about life outside work as well (think virtual water cooler) can have a significant impact on mental health.

Check-in with employees regularly.

Managers should check in with remote employees daily by phone or email to keep tabs on projects and make sure they have what they need. In addition, set up weekly meetings on Zoom or over the phone to track goal progress, talk about any struggles or challenges employees have, and acknowledge successes.

Implement remote recognition strategies.

Recognition is a key component of engagement, and that's just as true for remote workers as it is for those in the office. A simple thank you can go a long way toward developing trust and morale among team members. In addition, develop more structured recognition strategies to reward productivity and progress toward goals.

Ramp up communication from managers and team leaders.

It's virtually impossible to over-communicate in a remote work. Use video conferencing, social channels, chat tools, email, and phone calls to stay connected with teams and make sure everyone has what they need to get work done. Implement weekly or monthly staff meetings where people can "see" each other on a video call, create daily work checklists, encourage employees to reach out with questions or problems, and provide frequent performance feedback.

Offer flexible working hours.

Working in a home office isn't as straightforward as clocking in at your office building. Employees may be trying to share a workspace with a spouse or partner who is also working from home, and they may also be caring for children. In these scenarios, it is helpful to offer flexible work hours so your team members can stagger care responsibilities and working hours with a partner. If the role permits, shift the focus to performance expectations rather than being on the clock during specific hours.

References

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